Parenting Education and Support for Imprisoned Mothers

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Background

The U.S. incarcerates more people than any country in the world.[1] Although female offenders represent 7% of the overall U.S. prison population, the rate of female incarceration has increased substantially faster than that of men.[2] The number of incarcerated women in the United States increased by 25% between the years 2000 and 2007.[2] Today there are more than 200,000 women incarcerated in U.S. prison and jails.[3] Most incarcerated women are of childbearing age and approximately 6-10% of incarcerated women are pregnant when they enter prison.[4] These high rates of maternal incarceration have consequently impacted millions of children. Between 1991-2007, the number of children with a mother in prison has more than doubled, up 131%.[5]

Purpose

In this study, we examined incarcerated mothers' participation in a 12-week, prison-based parenting support program. In particular, we assessed mothers' contact with their children, as well as changes in participants' reports of parenting confidence and knowledge, levels of stress related to parenting, support received from other parenting and pregnant women, and support received from staff between the start and the end of the 12 week program.

Methods

Program Description

Isis Rising is a prison-based pregnancy and parenting support group comprised of two components – 1) a weekly New Moms Group for women who are pregnant or parenting and 2) a Doula Program for pregnant women receiving one-on-one birth planning and support from a trained doula. For the purpose of the study, we focused on outcomes among women who participated in the 12-week New Moms Group.

Measures

During the first class of the 12-week session, women completed an Initial Survey. The Initial Survey contained Likert-type and open-ended questions about parenting and participants' relationships with their children. A Final Survey was administered during the last class session.

Specifically, women were asked to indicate their responses on a 5-point scale (e.g., "Rate your confidence as a parent", 1=not confident and 5=very confident) to each of the following questions:

1. Rate your confidence as a parent.
1. Rate your level of parenting knowledge.
1. Rate your level of stress related to being a parent.
1. Rate the support you have received from other parenting/pregnant women in Shakopee.
1. Rate the support you have gotten from staff at Shakopee.



Results

Table 1. ***Sample Characteristics***

	Range	*Mean* (*SD*)
Age (in years)	19-40	27.50 (5.40)
Length of sentence (in months)	1-14	3.42 (2.59)
Entire sentence length (in months)	3-62	18.52 (15.98)
Number of children	0-9	2.76 (1.93)

Figure 1. ***Racial and Ethnic Characteristics of Isis Rising Participants***



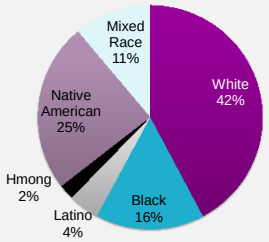


Table 2. ***Frequency of Mother's Contact with their Children in the Past Month, by Type of Contact***

	Range	Mean (SD)
Letters	0-10	2.02 (2.72)
Phone Calls	0-100	14.82 (23.07)
Visits	0-9	.52 (1.52)

Table 3. ***Paired-Sample T-Tests - Initial and Final Surveys***

	Initial Survey Week 1	Final Survey Week 12		
	Mean (*SD*)	*Mean* (*SD*)	*t*-statistic	p-value
Support received from other pregnant and parenting inmates	2.92 (1.20)	3.58 (.93)	**-3.46**	**.001**
Support received from Shakopee staff	2.08 (1.11)	2.61 (.98)	**-2.75**	**.009**
Parenting stress	3.28 (1.03)	3.05 (1.05)	1.42	.164
Confidence in parenting	4.03 (1.01)	4.33 (.82)	**-2.27**	**.029**
Parenting knowledge	4.26 (.79)	4.28 (.72)	-2.40	.812

Discussion

- Phone calls were the most common form of communication between mothers and their children; in-person visits were relatively limited.
- After 12 weeks of program participation, women reported significantly more confidence as a parent, as well as increased support from other incarcerated mothers and prison staff.
- The increase in women's confidence as parents and the support gained from other women by participating in the New Moms Group can be invaluable, as women in prison are among the most vulnerable women in society. Mental health is a primary concern for women in prison, and parenting programs such as the Isis Rising New Moms Group affords mothers the opportunity to learn coping strategies for dealing with the stress of separation and to improve communication with children and caregivers.
- The pilot data from the Isis Rising New Moms Support Group are promising. Future research includes assessing the relationship between the child's current caregiver and the incarcerated mother as one avenue for enhancing the quality of mothers' communication with their children.

Limitations

- Data were collected from a small group of women residing in one state prison; as such, the small sample size limits the study's generalizability.
- These data rely solely on participants' self-reports. Future research would benefit from combining participants' self-reports with objective measures of participants' behavior.
- The current study does not include a control group; thus, we can only assess within group differences among program participants. Future studies should be experimental in design and compare program participation to treatment as usual.

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